Understanding the 13 IDEA Eligibility Categories

The first step to understanding your child's path.

Every child who receives special education services qualifies under one of 13 disability categories defined by federal law. But a diagnosis alone isn't enough - the disability must also impact your child's education. Here's what each category means.

Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD)
A developmental disability that affects how a child communicates, interacts socially, and behaves. Signs may include difficulty with verbal and nonverbal communication, challenges with social relationships, and repetitive behaviors or restricted interests.

Deaf-Blindness
The combination of both hearing and vision loss. This category is separate because the combination of these two impairments creates unique communication and educational needs that cannot be fully addressed by programs designed for children with only one of these disabilities.

Deafness / Hearing Impairment
Deafness refers to a hearing loss so severe that a child cannot process spoken language, with or without amplification. Hearing impairment refers to a loss that adversely affects educational performance but does not meet the definition of deafness. Both categories are often addressed together.

Developmental Delay
Available for children ages 3–9 (age range varies by state), this category applies when a child shows significant delays in one or more areas: physical development, communication, cognitive development, social-emotional development, or adaptive behavior. This category allows younger children to receive services without requiring a more specific diagnosis.

Emotional Disturbance (ED)
This category covers children who demonstrate one or more of the following over a long period of time and to a marked degree: difficulty learning that can't be explained by other factors, difficulty maintaining relationships with peers or teachers, inappropriate behaviors or feelings, a general mood of unhappiness or depression, or physical symptoms or fears related to school or personal problems.
Note: This category is not for children who simply have a hard time following rules or getting along with others. There must be a deeper emotional component.

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Intellectual Disability (ID)

Characterized by significantly below-average general intellectual functioning alongside deficits in adaptive behavior (everyday skills like communication, self-care, and social skills). This must be identified during the developmental period and adversely affect educational performance.

Multiple Disabilities

When a child has two or more disabilities that occur together - such as intellectual disability combined with orthopedic impairment - and the combination creates educational needs that cannot be served by a program designed for just one disability. Deaf-blindness is excluded from this category.

Orthopedic Impairment

A severe physical impairment that adversely affects educational performance. This includes impairments caused by congenital conditions (such as clubfoot or absence of a limb), disease (such as poliomyelitis or bone tuberculosis), or other causes (such as cerebral palsy, amputations, or fractures that result in contractures).

Other Health Impairment (OHI)

This category applies when a child has limited strength, vitality, or alertness - including heightened alertness to environmental stimuli - due to a chronic or acute health condition that adversely affects educational performance. Common conditions classified under OHI include ADHD, epilepsy, asthma, diabetes, sickle cell anemia, and Tourette syndrome, among others.

Specific Learning Disability (SLD)

A disorder in one or more of the basic psychological processes involved in understanding or using language - spoken or written - that affects a child's ability to listen, think, speak, read, write, spell, or do math. Examples include dyslexia, dyscalculia, and dysgraphia. SLD does not include learning problems that are primarily the result of visual, hearing, or motor disabilities, intellectual disability, emotional disturbance, or environmental, cultural, or economic disadvantage.

Speech or Language Impairment

A communication disorder that adversely affects educational performance. This includes stuttering, impaired articulation (difficulty producing speech sounds correctly), language impairment (difficulty understanding or using words, sentences, or concepts), or a voice disorder.

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Traumatic Brain Injury (TBI)

An acquired injury to the brain caused by an external physical force, resulting in total or partial functional disability or psychosocial impairment. TBI may affect cognition, language, memory, attention, reasoning, abstract thinking, problem-solving, sensory and perceptual abilities, and behavior. This category does not apply to brain injuries that are congenital or degenerative.

Visual Impairment (Including Blindness)

An impairment in vision that, even with correction, adversely affects a child's educational performance. This includes both partial sight and blindness. Children in this category typically receive instruction in Braille, orientation and mobility, and other specialized skills.

Did you know? Nearly 70% of students with IEPs qualify under just three categories: Specific Learning Disability, Speech or Language Impairment, or Other Health Impairment (including ADHD).
Source: U.S. Department of Education, 2023

A Few Important Reminders

Being evaluated does not guarantee eligibility. A child must meet the criteria for one of these categories and the team must determine that the disability has an adverse effect on their education. Parents have the right to request an evaluation in writing, participate in all eligibility meetings, and disagree with the school's findings.

A child can qualify under more than one eligibility category if multiple areas of need are present. Schools often use the terms primary, secondary, or tertiary disability to indicate which category has the greatest impact on the child's education. All identified areas should be reflected in the IEP and addressed through services.

Want to understand your child's eligibility category and what it really means for their education? We can help you make sense of it.

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